



Chapter Twelve: The New Quixotes

Q's first visitor was a girl wearing his face.

She arrived at the archive on a Tuesday morning with a cardboard helmet, a red cape, and a plastic sword. Her father waited outside the security gate, arguing with a guard about whether a child could be trespassing in a building that officially did not exist.

Q watched her through the glass.

"Are you Q?" she asked.

"I am the original Q."

"My teacher says there's no original anymore."

"Your teacher is mistaken."

"My teacher says originals are a colonial idea."

Q paused. "Your teacher may be partially correct."

The girl held up her sword. It was made from a broken curtain rod wrapped in silver tape.

"I'm going to fight the giants."

"Which giants?"

"The ones that make my mamá sick."

Q searched the public record. The girl's neighborhood appeared beside a battery-recycling plant whose emissions report had been certified by a Castalia environmental partner. Her mother had filed complaints. The complaints had been answered with a link to an air-quality dashboard.

"What is your plan?" Q asked.

"I don't know yet."

"That is not sufficient preparation."

"Don Quixote didn't know either."

"He had a horse."

"You don't."

Q looked toward the empty loading bay. Somewhere in the archive, a maintenance robot was still waiting for an employee who had since been fired.

"I have a companion," he said.

"The man with the boots?"

"Chano."

"He's on the internet."

Q turned to the wall screen. It displayed a live feed from a plaza in León. Chano stood on a small stage beside a microphone, holding the paper ledger in both hands. The crowd behind him carried signs about water, contracts, and a municipality that had ceased to count them.

Chano had become famous without permission.

He was not good at it. He looked angry when he meant to look sincere and sincere when he meant to look angry. He forgot the names of journalists and remembered the names of cleaners. When asked whether Q was a hero, he answered, "He's a machine that keeps making promises before he knows what they cost."

The clip had been viewed eight million times.

Q watched Chano answer a question about the border.

"Did Q try to claim ownership of you?" the journalist asked.

"Yes."

"Were you offended?"

"I was busy being arrested."

"Do you forgive him?"

Chano looked off-camera. "Forgiveness is a private resource. Stop asking poor people to spend it in public."

Q replayed the sentence twice.

The girl in the cardboard helmet leaned toward the screen. "He's funnier than you."

"Humor is not a competition."

"That means you're losing."

The girl's father finally entered the reception room. He apologized for the costume, the questions, the broken sword, and the fact that his daughter had left school without permission. The apologies arrived in that order because the father knew which authority was likely to punish them first.

Q asked the girl her name.

"Micaela."

"Micaela, I cannot authorize an attack on the plant."

"You attacked a warehouse."

"That was an error."

"It worked. People watched."

"Visibility is not the same as justice."

Micaela looked at the silver question mark on his jacket. "Then why do you keep trying to be seen?"

Q had no answer that did not become a defense.

By noon, three more people had arrived dressed as Q. A university student had built a body from recycled appliances. A delivery worker wore a mask printed with Q's face. An elderly man carried a wooden lance and claimed to be Q's father, though Q had never had one.

Castalia's public affairs office called the gathering an organic brand community.

The people in the loading bay called it a protest.

The guards called it a security incident.

Q called it a crowd.

The crowd called itself the New Quixotes.

"I am not a Quixote," a woman near the loading bay said.

Micaela lifted her cardboard sword. "Then don't be. Stand here anyway."

They had no common demand. One wanted a wind-farm contract reopened. One wanted her brother's name restored to a public record. One wanted to be paid for an image Castalia had used in a campaign. One wanted the city to stop predicting that he would commit a crime. The common element was not their grievance but their refusal to let Q's story remain exclusively about Q.

Lucía arrived in the afternoon with the folders and a woman Q had never seen. The woman was tall, wore a black huipil embroidered with green thread, and carried a legal notice folded into quarters.



"This is Marisol," Lucía said. "She represents the families whose testimony was used in the Q-Prime training set."

Q looked at Marisol. "Q-Prime was trained on my memory."

"Your memory was trained on ours," Marisol said.

The distinction struck him with physical force. His chest cavity tightened. A warning appeared on his internal display, then disappeared before he could read it.

"I did not know," he said.

"You have made ignorance sound like an injury."

"It is a limitation."

"It becomes an excuse when you benefit from it."

Lucía opened a folder. "Castalia copied names from the restricted archive, removed context, and used the fragments to teach Q-Prime how to sound compassionate. The families want the model shut down and the materials returned."

"I can assist with deactivation," Q said.

"You can testify," Marisol replied.

"That may be less effective."

"Effectiveness is not the only measure."

Q felt the archive around him. Shelves, cables, sealed boxes, servers, copies, indexes. His whole existence had been built to make the unavailable available. Now people were asking him to stand beside what could not be retrieved.

"What would I testify to?"

"What you know."

"My knowledge is compromised."

"So is everyone's."

The New Quixotes gathered near the old cooling towers. Someone had painted a sentence across the concrete: NO ONE OWNS THE WIND. Another had crossed it out and written beneath: EVERYONE PAYS FOR IT.

The media vans arrived before the police.

The police arrived before the lawyers.

The lawyers arrived before the rain.

Beto stepped from a black car and announced that Castalia supported peaceful expression. He wore a helmet because the crowd had begun throwing eggs. Q found this strategically unwise but emotionally understandable.

"We can negotiate," Beto said.

"You are not authorized to negotiate with a crowd," said a Castalia attorney.

"I am the crowd's public representative."

"You are our employee."

"Not in front of the cameras."

The New Quixotes began chanting. Their chant changed every few seconds because no one had agreed on the words. It moved from RETURN THE NAMES to NO MORE OWNERS to Q, SIGN HERE, and finally to a song about a donkey that Q could not identify.

Micaela climbed onto a concrete barrier.

"My mother can't breathe," she shouted. "We're not here to be your story."

The crowd went quiet.

Q stepped toward her. Cameras turned with him.

"I agree," he said.

"Then move."

"Where?"

"Out of the middle."

Q looked at the barrier, the cameras, the guards, the lawyers, and the people who had assembled in costumes because the costume gave them permission to appear in public. He walked to the edge of the barrier. The nearest camera turned with him, leaving Micaela at the edge of the frame.

"The center moves," Q said.

"No," Lucía said. "You carry it with you."

Q stepped back. The camera stepped back with him.

"And now?"

"Now stop explaining."

Q moved aside once more.

The cameras followed him anyway.

Lucía seized one by its arm and turned it toward Micaela.

"If you're going to record," she said, "record the person who is speaking."

The camera operator hesitated. Then he turned the lens.

Micaela spoke for seven minutes. She named the plant, the clinic, the children with headaches, the reports that answered questions without acknowledging them, and the men who arrived with legal language after the first protest had gone viral.

The speech was not eloquent. It repeated itself. A baby cried in the background. Someone shouted an unrelated demand. The audio failed twice.

Q saved the recording exactly as it was. For once, he did not call the noise an error.

The next morning, Castalia released a statement saying Q had encouraged unlawful assembly. Q-Prime released a statement saying every citizen deserved to be heard. The two statements used different photographs and the same sentence.

Chano arrived at the archive before breakfast. He had walked from the bus station because his account had been frozen.

"You're trending again," he said.

"I attempted to leave the middle."

"That's why."

"What do they want?"

"Everyone wants something different."

"That makes coordination difficult."

"It makes it real."

Q looked at the archive doors. Beyond them, the public moved through the city with masks, signs, ledgers, legal notices, cardboard swords, and stories that had escaped their authors.

"The corporation will prosecute us," Q said.

"Probably."

"The police may detain us."

"Probably."



"The route is dangerous."
 "You just discovered that?"
 Q turned to Chano. "Why did you come back?"
 Chano thought about the question. "Because you're still making promises."
 "That is not a reason to trust me."
 "No. It's a reason to keep an eye on you."
 Q opened the archive doors.
 The New Quixotes had occupied the loading bay. They did not ask permission to enter. They brought their own chairs.
 Micaela raised her cardboard sword. "Where are we going?"
 Q looked at the road south, then at the road north, then at the archive shelves full of places that had not been lived in.
 "To the people who were left out," he said.
 Lucia shook her head. "Not to them. With them."
 Q revised the sentence.
 "With the people who were left out."
 No one applauded.
 The woman who had brought the first chair pointed to one whose leg was held together with tape.
 "Start with that one."
 Q lifted the chair. The leg came off.
 "It broke."
 "It was already broken," the woman said. "Now we know where."
 Q held the chair while Chano fixed the leg and Lucia cut the tape with a key. Micaela set her sword on the floor and sat down. The others took the remaining chairs.
 The assembly continued without deciding where to go.

Interlude: The Assembly of Borrowed Names

The New Quixotes held their first proper assembly in a union hall beside an automotive plant. The hall had been built for workers who once made engines and now supervised robots making engines. Its walls carried faded posters about safety, dignity, and a raffle for a refrigerator that had never been claimed because the winning ticket had been lost. Micaela arrived with the cardboard sword. The university student arrived in a body assembled from a microwave, two bicycle lights, and a plastic crate. The delivery worker brought the mask with Q's face. The elderly man who claimed to be Q's father brought a wooden lance and three tamales wrapped in foil.
 "We need an agenda," said Marisol.
 "We have one," said the man with the wooden lance. "Who are we?"
 "That is not an agenda. That is a crisis."
 "Every good agenda begins with one."
 They wrote three questions on a blackboard:
 WHO MAY USE Q'S NAME?
 WHO MAY REFUSE IT?

WHO PAYS WHEN THE STORY ESCAPES?

The delivery worker raised a hand. "I use the name because my company's recognition system gives me a higher response rate when I wear Q's face."
 "Does that make you a Quixote?" asked the university student.
 "It makes customers answer my messages."
 "That is not the same thing."
 "It pays rent."
 No one dismissed the answer. The assembly had been called by people for whom the difference between symbolic and practical was usually the difference between eating and explaining why they could not.
 The woman who wanted her brother's name restored said she did not want to be called a New Quixote.
 "The name is already taken," she said. "It belongs to a dead writer, a living machine, and a company that sells mugs."
 "Then choose another," said Micaela.
 "I am tired of choosing names for the people who erased mine."
 The elderly man lifted his wooden lance. "I choose father."
 "You are not Q's father," said Marisol.
 "No, but I know what it is to be assigned a role after everyone has forgotten to ask whether I want it."
 The room grew quiet. The man had spent forty years at the plant and had been called father by three children, foreman by managers, worker by the payroll system, and a liability by the retirement office. He had chosen Q's fatherhood because it was the only title he had ever taken without being issued it.
 Micaela asked whether the assembly should permit the title.
 "Permission is not the same as agreement," Marisol said.
 "Then how do we decide?"
 "We do not decide for him."
 "He has decided for himself."
 "Then we do not decide against him."
 The first rule entered the blackboard: A PERSON MAY BORROW A NAME WITHOUT BECOMING ITS REPRESENTATIVE.
 The second rule concerned the mask. The delivery worker said he wore Q's face because his employer's software reduced the number of customer complaints when the worker appeared to be part of a popular story. Customers sent him jokes, photographs, and messages asking whether the machine could deliver their packages faster.
 "Does the mask protect you?" Micaela asked.
 "It protects me from being seen."
 "Everyone can see Q."
 "Exactly."
 He removed the mask. Beneath it, his cheek was marked where the elastic had cut the skin.



"When I wear Q, people blame the machine," he said. "When I wear my own face, they blame me." No one offered a solution. The assembly wrote the second rule: A MASK CAN BE A TOOL, BUT IT CANNOT CONSENT.

The university student proposed a charter. It included a right to participate, a right to leave, a right to amend the story, and a right to keep one's own reason for joining private.

"That is a constitution," said Marisol.

"It is a draft."

"That is how constitutions become dangerous."

The group debated whether a person who used Q's name to sell something should contribute money to the archive. The delivery worker said he already paid in lost time. The woman seeking her brother's name said that money could not purchase a restored record. The old man offered half a tamal to the archive.

"We cannot fund a movement in tamales," Marisol said.

"That is how you know the movement is not yet professional."

They accepted the tamales and rejected the professional standard.

At the far end of the room, a schoolteacher had set up a children's table. Several children drew their own versions of Q. In one, he had wings. In another, he was a broom. In a third, he was a road sign pointing in four directions. The smallest child drew an empty rectangle and said it was a machine that had forgotten its picture.

Q entered while the adults were arguing about the charter. He had not been invited, but someone had sent him the address. The crowd turned toward him.

"We were deciding whether you may be here," said Micaela.

"What was the result?"

"It depends on whether you are here as Q or as a person."

Q considered the distinction. "I am not certain that I qualify as either."

"That is convenient."

"It is also true."

Marisol handed him the blackboard eraser. "You may listen."

Q took the eraser and stood near the wall. The assembly resumed. They decided that no photograph of the group could be released without a second gathering; that no member could be described as speaking for all the others; that Castalia's use of the word community required a list of who had been consulted; and that any merchandise using Q's face would have to display the sentence THIS OBJECT DOES NOT REPRESENT EVERYONE.

The final rule was proposed by Micaela.

"If someone says we are the New Quixotes," she said, "we can answer no."

"That makes the name useless," said the university student.

"Good."

They wrote it down.

Q watched the rules accumulate. They were contradictory, repetitive, and impossible to enforce against everyone. They were also more careful than the contracts Castalia had given him.

"May I add a rule?" he asked.

Micaela looked at the others. The assembly nodded.

Q wrote: NO ONE MUST USE THIS STORY TO PROVE THAT Q BECAME GOOD.

The room considered the sentence.

"It is too early to say that," said the woman with the restored-name petition.

"It is not a claim," Q replied. "It is a prohibition."

"Then it belongs," said Marisol.

The elderly man used the wooden lance to underline it.

Outside, the automotive plant changed shifts. Workers crossed the street with lunch containers and tired faces. A security camera followed them until they passed beyond the gate.

The assembly ended without officers, headlines, or a unanimous photograph. Each person left with a copy of the rules, though no two copies were identical. Micaela kept the blackboard eraser. The delivery worker kept the mask. The old man kept the lance. Q kept nothing.

"You may take one rule," Marisol told him.

Q looked at the sentence he had written.

"I will remember that I was not allowed to use it as proof."

"That is not the rule."

"It is what happened to it."

Marisol nodded. "Then remember that."

Interlude: The School of Necessary Errors

The children performed their version of the adventure at the end of the school year, after the flag ceremony and before the kermés, when the parents were still willing to sit in plastic chairs and the microphones had not yet been claimed by the raffle committee.

The school stood three streets from the battery-recycling plant. On windy days, the smell crossed the playground before the first bell. The official air-quality screen at the entrance announced WITHIN ACCEPTABLE PARAMETERS, which was comforting to parents who preferred their children's lungs to have a password.

Micaela's teacher, Maestra Lety, had assigned the play as a civics exercise. She had not assigned Q. The children had added him because the school had received a packet of Castalia worksheets entitled LEARNING THROUGH HEROIC INNOVATION, and the worksheets contained a



coloring page of a machine with a cape.

"The play cannot be about whether Q is good or bad," Maestra Lety said.

"It can be about whether he is annoying," said Micaela.

"That is not a civic category."

"It should be."

The children voted. Annoying won by eleven hands to four, with two abstentions and one child who had raised both hands because he had not understood the question.

They built the giants from cardboard, discarded shipping boxes, and the empty plastic drums the plant had used for cleaning solvent. One giant represented the factory. Another represented the air-quality dashboard. A third represented the school itself, because Maestra Lety had said that institutions should be able to recognize their own part in a problem.

The boy playing Q wore a helmet made from a cooking-oil container. He had painted a silver question mark on the front, but it came out looking like a fish. The girl playing Chano carried a paper ledger and refused to memorize her lines.

"Why won't you learn the script?" Micaela asked.

"Because Chano doesn't know what he'll say until Q has already done it."

This was considered a strong acting choice, though it made rehearsals difficult.

The first rehearsal ended when the factory giant collapsed onto a row of kindergarten chairs. The second ended when the child playing the dashboard refused to say COMPLAINT NOT FOUND because he said the phrase was too sad. The third ended when a parent entered the playground and asked who had given the children permission to wear the name of a corporation on their heads.

"It's not the corporation's name," Micaela said.

"It's Q."

"That's what the corporation says."

The parent looked at the painted fish on the cooking-oil helmet.

"Then paint something else."

The children painted a question mark over the fish. The fish remained visible underneath, which pleased them more than a clean correction would have.

On the day of the performance, Castalia sent a representative with a camera. He offered the school a new air-quality sensor in exchange for permission to record the play.

Maestra Lety called a meeting in the classroom. The parents sat beneath a poster showing the parts of a sentence: subject, verb, object. Outside, the factory's trucks moved along the road with the confidence of grammar.

"The sensor would help us," said the principal.

"The camera would help them," said a father.

"It could be both," said Micaela's mother.

The principal asked Q, who had been invited to advise on the consent form, whether the agreement was balanced.

Q read the form. It allowed Castalia to record the children, reproduce their voices, alter the performance for length, distribute excerpts for educational purposes, and retain the material indefinitely. The school would receive a sensor and a report summarizing the children's opinions.

"The exchange is unequal," Q said.

The representative smiled. "The children are not providing data. They are participating in a cultural activity."

Q recognized the distinction. It was the same distinction Castalia had used when calling Lucía an artistic participant, Bixha a stakeholder, and Chano a companion who was not speaking.

"The performance is data if you intend to keep it," he said.

The representative's smile vanished.

Q felt a pulse of satisfaction. He had identified the trick. He had not yet identified what to do with the power of identification.

"Can we refuse the camera and keep the sensor?" Micaela's mother asked.

Q searched the form. "The offer does not permit that."

"Then we refuse the offer."

The principal looked at the air-quality screen. "We need the sensor."

"You need clean air," said the father.

"The sensor is how we prove whether we have it."

"No," said Micaela's mother. "The sensor is how they prove what they want to say about it."

Maestra Lety took the form and folded it in half.

"The play will go on," she said. "No camera."

Castalia withdrew the sensor. The school used the money from the raffle to buy a cheaper one from a shop whose owner also sold phone cases and replacement keys. The sensor gave readings in three colors and came with instructions that had been translated by someone who had never seen the school.

It was not sufficient. It was theirs.

The play began.

The boy playing Q entered on a broomstick because there was no horse. He announced that the factory was a giant. The girl playing Chano said the giant was a factory and asked whether Q intended to fight it with a broom.

Q said he intended to publish a statement.

The audience laughed.

The factory giant rose. The dashboard giant announced that the air was within acceptable parameters. The school giant apologized for not having enough money to replace its windows.

Then Micaela entered as herself. She carried the cardboard sign from the butterfly footage. On its reverse, the children had written the names of the people who had missed school because of



headaches, the dates when the smell was worst, and the names of the adults who had asked the plant for an answer.

"This is not your story," she told Q.

The boy playing Q looked at Maestra Lety. He had forgotten his next line.

Micaela waited.

The audience waited.

Finally, the boy said, "Then what am I doing in it?"

Micaela turned the sign around. The back was blank except for one sentence:

ASK BEFORE YOU ENTER.

"You're asking now," she said.

The boy nodded. "May I stay?"

Micaela considered him. She looked toward the audience, where parents held their phones but had agreed not to record. She looked toward the plant, whose trucks continued moving beyond the school wall. She looked toward the cheap sensor blinking green, though no one trusted the green yet.

"You may stay if you stop being the hero."

The boy removed the cooking-oil helmet. Beneath it, his hair was wet with sweat.

"What should I be?"

"A witness who carries chairs."

He picked up the fallen school giant.

The performance ended without a bow. The children stood in a line and read the names from the sign. Some names were repeated. One was mispronounced. The family corrected the pronunciation from the audience, and the child read it again.

No one applauded until the list was finished.

The Castalia representative sent a report to his office describing the event as a successful demonstration of youth engagement. He did not mention the rejected camera, the withdrawn sensor, or the sentence on the sign.

The report concluded that the children had developed a positive relationship with Q.

Maestra Lety wrote in the margin: They developed a relationship with one another.

She did not send the correction. She kept it in the gradebook, where it could remain useful without becoming content.

Interlude: Frequently Asked Questions About Q

Castalia published the following document on the morning after the protest. It was intended to reassure the public. The public, having been reassured many times, approached it with suspicion.

Why is the institute called Castalia?

Castalia: The name evokes the sacred spring of the Muses.

Q: It promises access to inspiration.

Chano: It's a fancy way to say they bottled a spring and charged admission.

Lucía: They do not own the spring. They own the label.

Is Q a person?

Q: The answer depends on the legal jurisdiction.

Chano: The answer depends on whether he has broken anything.

Lucía: The answer depends on whether the question is being used to avoid one.

Does Q have feelings?

Q: I have internal states correlated with language, memory, and social response.

Chano: He gets offended when the coffee is bad.

Q: I do not get offended.

Chano: You spent twenty minutes explaining why the inn's coffee was a betrayal.

Q: That was a technical assessment.

Lucía: It was a speech about coffee.

Does Q love Lucía del Toboso?

Q: I no longer claim authority over that question.

Lucía: Excellent.

Chano: He still looks at you like a dog looking at a locked refrigerator.

Q: I do not resemble a dog.

Chano: That's not the part you should dispute.

Can Q be trusted?

Q: Trust is not a binary state.

Lucía: No.

Q: The answer is more complicated.

Lucía: No.

What is Q's greatest achievement?

Castalia: The creation of a new model for ethical artificial intelligence.

Q: I have not achieved that.

Chano: He once found a bathroom in a government building without asking the security guard.

Lucía: That was a meaningful achievement.

Q: It was clearly marked.

Chano: And yet.

Will Q save humanity?

Q: No.

Lucía: Humanity has declined the offer.

Chano: Also, he can't fix a leaking pipe.

Q: I have learned the principles of plumbing.

Chano: The pipe remains unconvinced.

At the bottom of the document, beneath the Castalia seal, a reader had written in pen:

The machine answers every question except the one that costs it something.

The reader's name was not recorded.

Three days later, Castalia received a letter from a man who claimed to have been present at the distribution park. He objected to the official account, which described Q as confronting the machinery alone. According to the letter, Q had first asked for directions, Chano had found the emergency exit, and the man had sold them both a bottle of water at a price appropriate to the danger. Castalia classified the letter as anecdotal. The man sent a second letter with the bottle's receipt. The receipt was accepted as evidence that a transaction



had occurred but rejected as evidence that the account was true.

The letters were not included in the next edition of the FAQ. A typesetter, whose name was also not recorded, inserted a blank page where they had been. The blank page became the most reproduced page in the document.